

2142 BATTLEFIELD

Frosty Wargrounds



Rating: 8/10
Developer: DICE
Publisher: EA Games
Minimum System Requirements:
Pentium 4 1.7 GHz, 512 MB RAM,
128 MB DirectX 9.0b compatible
graphics card, DirectX 9
compatible sound

The hailed multiplayer experience that is the *Battlefield* franchise returns for a fourth burst in *Battlefield 2142*. No rewards for guessing that *2142* is based in its namesake year. The world has been plunged into an ice age, and wars take place for habitable land, just as in the earlier *Battlefield* games. There are two teams—a European coalition and the Russians—and they'll fight it out from Europe to Africa; understandable, since Africa's climes will be warmer...

Players of *Battlefield 2* will feel at home with *2142*. The player classes are down though from seven to just four, but the developers have made these more

flexible. Gameplay is very similar, with the vehicles and weaponry functioning similarly—why change a winning formula? It's only the futuristic look that distinguishes *2142* from *Battlefield 2*.

Speaking of vehicles, you have a few options depending on which side you play, but the differences between the Euro and Russian versions of the same vehicles and weapons (looks aside) is subtle. You can unlock special upgrades like grenades, advanced armour, and weaponry.

Great multiplayer needs great maps, and *2142* excels. The maps are sprawling and well-laid-out. Tactics are important while covering, moving or assaulting, and

no vantage point is invincible. You'll need to keep moving around, intelligently using cover, and co-ordinating strikes.

The Conquest and Co-op Conquest gameplay modes are still there, accompanied by an all-new Titan mode. The object here is to destroy the enemy Titan (a behemoth flying ship). Instead of capturing and holding control points, you must now capture and hold missile silos.

The missile silos under your control will periodically fire missiles on the enemy Titan, which is protected by an energy shield that slowly whittles away, exposing the ship itself to damage. You must now board the crippled Titan and blow up the four security terminals exposing the core to damage.

Titan battles are typically intense: you may be flying around capturing silos one second, and the next you're boarding the enemy Titan for an all-out close combat experience aboard its narrow corridors!

2142 uses a slightly tweaked *Battlefield 2* engine, which is starting to show its age with all the great-looking shooters popping up everywhere.

Aurally, the game is the same as its predecessor. If it works...don't fix it! Pity the start-game-take-coffee-break-like load times also remain unchanged. Running the game for the first time is one of the best ways to waste time! Thankfully, consecutive loads are much faster.

2142 is quite simply a great experience for you and your friends, but playing against bots isn't much fun. You'll need at least eight friends to get the fun started—the more the merrier!

michael_browne@thinkdigit.com